occasion, have urged the respective governments to go ahead with the creation of a CDS without further delay. I also accept that there are some genuinely convinced adherents of the view that the CDS must be appointed as early as possible.

There are some fundamental considerations that need to be kept in mind and examined by the government before a decision is taken. First, *integration* in the true sense must imply not only integration within the services, as is the case at present, but also within the ministry of defence and the service HQs, with a complement of experts at the appropriate level from ministries of external affairs, home, finance and so on. It should be normal to see officers of these ministries and the defence services working together as a 'team' in various offices, as is the practice in all democratic nations. This has to happen sooner than later, but is not in place yet.

Secondly, each country must evolve its own *defence structure at the apex level*. Conceptually, there cannot be one formula that would apply to all. Whatever structure is created, it must ensure the highest level of security of our nation. No turf-guarding exercises should be permitted to compromise or dilute the steps required to safeguard the country. The CDS has been pronounced as the single-point adviser on defence matters for the government, and so it should be. He should have unfettered access to the prime minister and defence minister at all times. His presence at the highest decision-making fora in the country during discussions on national security should be institutionalized.

The next issue that needs to be examined is about the *command and control* of the armed forces. In most of the countries that have adopted the CDS formula, the operational control of the armed forces has been vested in his hands. In our case, the GoM report has recommended 'status quo' as far as the command and control of the forces is concerned. That would render the CDS a toothless tiger, a 'super adviser' without a definable responsibility or accountability. One could call him a modern-day Birbal! A dangerous guy to have around, I would think. Further, it is debatable if in our hierarchical and seniority-driven system, a 'first among equals' concept would